



Qualification Programme Examination Panelist's Report

Module 4 – Business Management (June 2021 Session)

(The main purpose of the following report is to summarise candidates' common weaknesses and make recommendations to help future candidates improve their performance in the examination.)

(I) Section A – Multiple Choice Questions

General Comments

The multiple choice questions tested the candidates' fundamental knowledge of business management in various aspects, including marketing, strategic management, international business, control systems, and organisational behaviours. In addition, there were several questions that required candidates to apply a deeper understanding of the concepts and knowledge to different aspects of business management. Generally, candidates exhibited average performance for the conceptual questions but performed unsatisfactorily for the questions that required more application of the concepts.

Specific Comments

Candidates showed weaknesses in the following areas:

- Production and operations management
- Control systems and risks
- Financial management
- International business
- Service management

(II) Section B – Written Questions

General Comments

The questions in this section aimed at testing candidates on their conceptual understanding as well as their ability to apply their knowledge to specific company situations. It is very important that candidates respond to the questions in relation to the specific concepts and knowledge required under the different scenarios given in the questions.

In general, candidates tried their best to attempt to answer all the questions even though they might not have had a good understanding of the concepts. Most candidates formatted their answers well and listed their points clearly when answering the questions.



However, some candidates did not appear to allocate their time well as they appear to have spent significant time attempting to answer the first few questions, leading to insufficient time to answer the remaining questions.

Moreover, candidates performed well on straightforward questions to which they could directly find the answers from the scenarios; but when the questions required candidates to explain the concepts, many candidates gave confused or muddled responses. This may have been due to inadequate knowledge of the relevant concepts or insufficient preparation for the examination.

Specific Comments

Question 1(a) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe the internal environment of the company based on the scenario provided. However, many candidates were unable to score high marks despite this being a simple question.

Candidates may not have had sufficient knowledge and understanding of the internal environment of the company.

Question 1(b) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define customer satisfaction and customer loyalty and to state the relationship of these two to customer-oriented culture.

Many candidates were able to define the concepts of customer satisfaction and customer loyalty but were not able to state the relationship of these two to customer-oriented culture, which is that they lead to higher profit.

Question 2 – 10 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and explain other factors that should be considered when making debt financing decisions. Many candidates did not read the question carefully and still explained concepts that the question explicitly asked them to exclude. Thus, many candidates were unable to score high marks.

Question 3(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to explain a dilemma illustrated in the case scenario. The simple nature of this question allowed several candidates to achieve full marks. Most candidates scored some marks.

Question 3(b) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain the importance of implementing control systems for the company. Only around half of the candidates were able to answer this question with average performance.



Many candidates were not able to provide the correct answer because they did not discuss the importance of implementing control systems, rather, they explained the control activities.

Question 4 – 10 Marks

This question required candidates to list and explain the steps of Six Sigma. This question was quite straightforward as candidates could score high marks if they were able to remember the steps of Six Sigma and provide some explanation.

Some candidates were able to list the steps but were not able to explain them in great detail, preventing them from attaining full marks.

Question 5(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to explain what marketing channels should be adopted by the company based on the case information. Many candidates were able to provide good answers as they could get the answer easily from the case information. Thus, several candidates were able to score full marks for this question.

Question 5(b) – 12 Marks

This question required candidates to list and describe the pricing strategies and then identify and explain which strategy is the most appropriate for the company. Most candidates were able to list and describe the pricing strategies though some appear to have forgotten the exact term of a particular pricing strategy.

However, some candidates failed to explain which pricing strategy is appropriate for the company or incorrectly selected a strategy which is unable to help the short-term aim of the company.

Question 5(c) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the challenges that the company will encounter if it sells products online from a global perspective, but many candidates only provided the answers based on a local perspective. Thus, the discussions were not relevant to the scenario that the company is facing.

Question 6(a) – 10 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain the factors which should be considered when planning and implementing an appraisal system for the company. The performance of several candidates was poor because they did not understand the question or they provided irrelevant concepts.

Some candidates were able to state the factors but did not provide a structured and detailed discussion.



Question 6(b) – 5 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the five levels of Maslow's hierarchy of needs. Despite this question being very simple and straightforward, some candidates scored zero marks.

Other candidates, however, were able to score high marks and several scored full marks because they were able to provide comprehensive answers.

Question 6(c) – 5 Marks

This question required candidates to identify which levels have been fulfilled by the employees and explain how the company can link the appraisal results to career development and compensation with reference to the status of Maslow's hierarchy of needs.

Most candidates were able to identify which levels were fulfilled. However, they were unable to link the answers to the last two unfulfilled levels (i.e., esteem needs and self-actualisation needs) with regard to the appraisal results.

(III) Conclusion and Recommendation

Overall, the performance of the candidates was not satisfactory. Some of the candidates were able to provide answers related to the questions or the relevant concepts, especially when the concepts were easy or the information and answers could be found within the case background. However, when they were asked questions regarding difficult concepts which required significant reading and preparation before the examination, many candidates were unable to provide a detailed discussion (for example, Six Sigma, control systems, and pricing strategies). Some suggestions are provided below to advise candidates on how to better prepare for the examination.

Firstly, candidates are advised to read the questions carefully. Some of the candidates appear to have misunderstood or misread several questions. For example, one of the questions in this set of papers required candidates to state the importance of implementing the control systems. Most candidates, however, discussed the contents of the control systems.

Moreover, in relation to this point, candidates are advised to pay attention to the wording of the questions as well. Typically, candidates should write the main point first and then elaborate based on that particular point and relate the answers to the case information.

Secondly, candidates are advised to prepare and study the materials well. This module encompasses a large scope of different areas of studies; thus, if candidates are only familiar with areas which may be related to their jobs, they will not be able to complete the examination satisfactorily. It is important to prepare and study the materials well before the examination to achieve a clear understanding of the different concepts covered.



Thirdly, it is advised that candidates should pay attention to the time allotted to each question. Some candidates might not be aware of the time required to complete a particular question; thus, they might spend a significant amount of time on questions which are simpler and more straightforward, which would give them little time for longer questions which may require more analytical skills and application of concepts.

Finally, candidates are advised to elaborate on their points and provide an in-depth discussion for each point when handling questions. It is common for there to be marks for elaboration and answers with reference to the case information. Thus, candidates should provide elaborate discussions and try to relate the discussions to the case information.